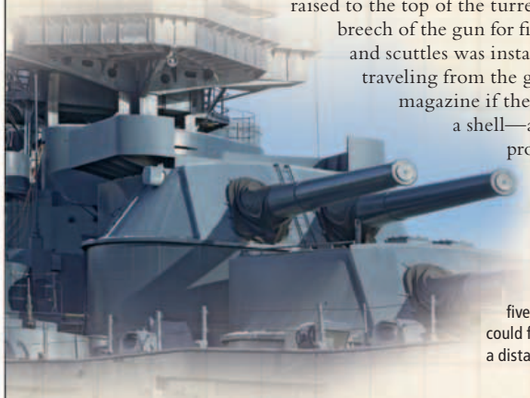
WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

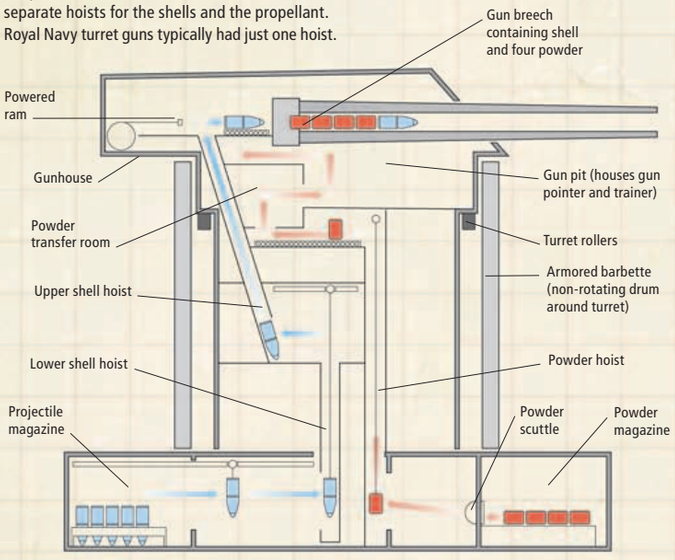
WWI TURRET GUNS

The large caliber naval guns on World War I capital ships were mounted in turrets protected by armored barbettes and supported on a bed of rollers to allow the guns to rotate. A gunhouse above deck was linked by a tube, known as the main trunk, to the magazine and shell room deep inside the ship. The shells were too heavy to lift by hand, so to load the gun the shells and propellant charges were placed on a hoist that carried them up the trunk to a working chamber. From there they were raised to the top of the turret and rammed into the breech of the gun for firing. A series of doors and scuttles was installed to prevent flash traveling from the gunhouse down to the magazine if the gunhouse was hit by a shell—although Royal Navy procedures at Jutland were defective in this regard.



Battleship Texas
The battleship's ten 14-in guns, mounted in five turrets along her centerline, could fire 1,500-lb (680-kg) shells a distance of 13 miles (21 km).

US battleship turret gun
The turret guns on most American battleships of the period were divided into two sections with separate hoists for the shells and the propellant. Royal Navy turret guns typically had just one hoist.



WITNESS TO WAR

COMMANDER HUMPHREY WALWYN

EXECUTIVE OFFICER ON HMS WARSPITE

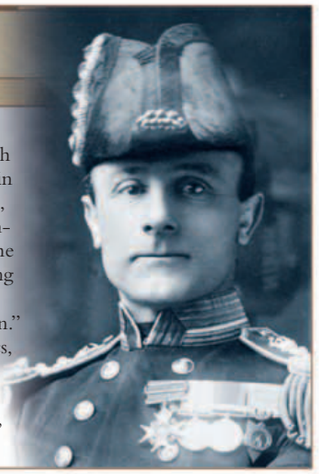
BATTLE OF JUTLAND

Very soon after the turn, could see leading ships of High Seas Fleet, hardly discernible but I counted six or eight. ***Long lines of orange flame seemed to ripple along continuously, and I realised they were firing at us****. Felt heavy shakes but didn't think much of it … Crossed Cook's lobby to port side and was just going forward to the fo'c'sle deck, when a 12-inch shell came in through the starboard side and burst with a* ***terrific sheet of flame, impenetrable dust, smoke, stink****, and everything seemed to fall from everywhere at once. Called for number two fire brigade and several rushed out and we got the fire out fairly easily, but* ***place was full of smoke and several men were sick—awful stench****."*

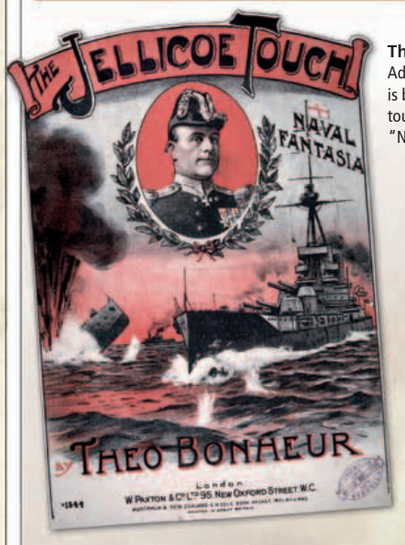
1859–1935

SIR JOHN JELLICOE

ADMIRAL OF THE BRITISH FLEET



Jellicoe joined the Royal Navy as a cadet in 1872 and saw action in the colonial wars of the late 19th century. As a senior administrator he participated in the reform of the Royal Navy before World War I, specializing in gunnery. Appointed commander-in-chief of the Grand Fleet at the outset of the war, he pursued a cautious strategy, ever-conscious of being in Winston Churchill's words, "the only man on either side who could lose the war in an afternoon." No politician, he was outmaneuvered by his critics, who were numerous after the battle of Jutland. In November 1916 he was appointed First Sea Lord, only to be precipitately dismissed 13 months later, a scapegoat for Admiralty failings.



The Jellicoe Touch
Admiral John Jellicoe's image is borrowed to add a patriotic touch to this collection of "Naval Fantasia" sheet music.

Battlecruisers at Jutland
Ships of the First Battlecruiser Squadron fire on the High Seas Fleet at Jutland while German shells splash into the water around them.